



Open ride

Agent 001 wants more than open source cars – he wants to get under the hood and see their “source”

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We’ve been rather liberal with our praise for open source – not to mention the warm fluffiness of “community” – in these pages, you might have noticed. But this month, I wanted to more than just review the result – I wanted to see this “source” they keep telling me about, and even contribute to a project, if I could (I probably can’t, but you never know).

And it wasn’t open source software that I was interested in – in this new world where everyone is touting an open source something-or-the-other, I thought I’d go poke around for one of the other somethings. A couple of open source car projects have been in the news recently – so I knew that they’d be my target. While I’m all for the idea of a car everyone can contribute to, I’ve always thought that the term “open source car” is rather fishy (and not just because I can’t download one of these), so investigations are in order.

OScar

(www.theoscarproject.org)

It seems that the OScar (for Open Source Car) project was the first on the scene – it started in 1999, which not long after it

became fashionable to call yourself open source. It went the “everyone’s invited” way in 2006, and we gave it a nod in our seventh anniversary issue in 2008.

The featured design – and what I can only assume is the most popular – is a three-wheeled affair, which apart from looking oddly cool, is also a rather shrewd approach. In several countries, three-wheelers get classified as motorcycles, and hence aren’t subject to stringent safety laws – which means that the cost of producing one of these gets dramatically lowered; that it may end up being the first community-built death trap shall not be commented upon. But enough of that. Time to get my hands dirty with some open source car designs.

Turns out that all the information I need is in the forum – everything from the body to the engine to the safety system. Pity, then, that the forum is “offline for maintenance” for the third week running, as of this writing. This does not bode well at all.

I decided to register on the site anyway, and found that there’s a “Wiki Test” link for registered users. “Aha!” I thought, in the manner of Captain Obvious, “a wiki!” The “Car Content So Far” section is meticulously categorised, and contains such insightful comments as “Level 1 Headline”, “lalala” and “:.)”, thus adequately explaining

the “Test” part of the title.

This is the part where I am overcome by that creepy feeling that I’m staring at a corpse that I shouldn’t really be staring at. Surely the project didn’t just roll over and die? Ah, well. Time to look away.

C,mm,n

(www.cmmn.org)

The annoyingly named c,mm,n (pronounced “common”; but seriously, what if we called ourselves D,g,t and asked you to “pronounce it right?”), unlike OScar, has a physical embodiment. In March 2007, c,mm,n became the world’s first open source car at AutoRAI, the Amsterdam car show.

The c,mm,n car runs on hydrogen fuel cells, has an iPhone-like dashboard that “flows through the car like a river”, and has the audacity to look like this:

But no, we must not focus on that annoying name or that silly design. It’s already one-upped the OScar in that it actually exists, and we must credit the project for that. Unlike the minimalist OScar, the c,mm,n is neck-deep in technology. There’s the aforementioned “river” dashboard, which will give you all the usual car features – speedometer, odometer and GPS route planner – and adds to it a news and email reader for when it’s in “convoy mode”. That, too, is an interesting part of the project – you can join a group of c,mm,ns and drive around as a convoy, where the cars communicate with each other and put appropriate distances between themselves, while you kick back with your New York Times newsfeed. The source for this is bound to be intriguing.

The c,mm,n project lets you join